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The Improbable Border Dispute

The Bumla Pass, high up in the eastern Himalayas and 5,000 metres above sea level, sits on the crest of the craggy mountain ranges that separate the Indian subcontinent from the Tibetan high plateau. Sharp, even taller peaks rise in the distance along the watershed that today forms the LAC between India and China. The air is thin, there are no villages in the vicinity, and the only local people who venture up here are semi-nomadic yak herdsmen. They cross freely between Chinese- and Indian-controlled territory with their beasts during the grazing season, which is in summer when the slopes of the mountains are covered in grass instead of snow.

Other outsiders are not allowed to visit Bumla without special permits issued by Indian authorities. This is a heavily militarized area and nearly all the vehicles on the narrow road that winds its way up to the pass are army trucks and jeeps. On the southern edge of the pass stands a cluster of solid buildings: a meeting hall, observation towers, and guard posts. A sign has been erected to show where the area under Indian control ends. It displays an Indian and a Chinese flag and the text ‘Two Old Neighbouring Civilisations. India, China, Partners in Progress’.[1] Bumla is one of the few places along the Sino-Indian boundary where army officers from both countries meet to discuss issues of mutual concern, or to celebrate each other’s national days. When that happens, the Chinese put up some tents, which are dismantled as soon as the events are over. There are no solid structures immediately on the other side of the pass, because that would, for the Chinese, be tantamount to recognizing that the crest of the mountains is the official border between the two countries.

This is the McMahon Line, which was named after Henry McMahon, the chief British negotiator at Shimla in 1913–14, and recognized by